

STUNTED CHILD CARE

Poorly paid workers forced to spend own money for eggs & veggies

Funds, fundas & more: 50 yrs on, nothing goes right for anganwadis

SHRINIDHI R
DHARWAD, DHNS

Tears well up in Basamma's eyes as she recounts her life of service. A resident of Koppal, Basamma has been working for over 20 years as an anganwadi worker, putting in nearly 10 hours a day for a modest honorarium of Rs 12,500 per month.

"I will be retiring in the next couple of years, but there are no post-retirement benefits. The only solace is that we have worked with dedication. Much more could have been achieved had successive governments responded positively to our demands," she says.

Basamma's story reflects the plight of thousands of anganwadi workers across Karnataka who work tirelessly to implement child and maternal health programmes.

Pre-nursery classes

Karnataka is among the few states where anganwadi centres have played a crucial role not only in running pre-nursery education centres, but also in combating malnutrition, reducing infant and maternal mortality rates, monitoring the health of undernourished children and providing nutritious food to pregnant and lactating women.

This year marks the golden jubilee of anganwadi centres in the state. Launched in 1975 in Mysuru district, the initiative later expanded across the state. However, despite completing 50 years and overcoming numerous challenges, the system has not evolved to its full potential.

While successive governments have introduced several health schemes to address malnutrition and promote

44 Every third child under the age of five years suffers from chronic malnutrition. Studies conducted in Belagavi and Koppal using WHO growth standards show 32% of children under five are underweight

Gopal Dabade
Social activist

institutional deliveries, issues faced by anganwadi workers have largely been ignored.

According to the women and child welfare department, Karnataka has 69,919 functional anganwadi centres. But due to inadequate funding and prolonged neglect, nearly 33.5%—about 16,000 centres—operate from rented buildings. Another 20% function out of ashraha houses, temple premises and community halls.

District-wise, 465 anganwadi centres in Dharwad operate from rented premises, followed by Belagavi (1,360), Tumakuru (568), Kalaburagi (600), Mysuru (265), Shivamogga (166), Mandya (161) and Hassan (116).

Crammed premises

"Running anganwadi centres from rented buildings poses several challenges. There is severe shortage of space, no separate kitchen and no playgrounds. Often, we are forced to pay rent from our own salaries due to delays in reimbursement by the department," said Savitri, an anganwadi worker from Koppal.

Another major concern is the rising cost of vegetables and eggs. Workers allege that fluctuating prices force them to pay the difference from their own pockets.

"Eggs currently cost between Rs 7 and Rs 8 each, but the government allocates only Rs 5 per egg. When we raise this issue, officials ask us to manage



A file photo of a protest by anganwadi workers and helpers in Bengaluru. Forming the basic units of infant and maternal care, anganwadi centres have remained perennially sick. Many operate out of rented buildings and have no separate kitchens or playgrounds.

within sanctioned funds or pay the difference ourselves. At times, we are even instructed to purchase eggs strictly within allotted funds, which means some children go without eggs," said Arati, an anganwadi worker from Dharwad.

The department has also advised some anganwadi centres to grow vegetables to meet nutritional requirements. However, workers say this is impractical given their workload and lack of time.

Services unregulated

All India United Trade Union Centre (AIUTUC) state president Somashekar Yadgir told *DH* that the demand to include anganwadi workers and helpers under group 'C' and 'D' cadres had remained unaddressed for

nearly two decades.

"At present, an anganwadi worker receives an honorarium of Rs 12,500. While a helper gets Rs 6,500. Given the rising prices, it is impossible to run the household on such meagre pay," he said.

He said while anganwadi working hours were earlier from 9 am to 1 pm, they have been extended up to 4 pm over the past three years without additional benefits.

Yadgir pointed out that even after 50 years, the integrated child development services continue to be treated as a scheme rather than a full-fledged department.

Earlier, the union government contributed 90% of the funding, but allocations were reduced after 2014. The state

government has not revised the honorarium, he said.

Malnourishment challenge

Social activist and secretary of Jagruti organisation Gopal Dabade said malnutrition continued to be a major public health challenge.

"Every third child under the age of five years suffers from chronic malnutrition. Studies conducted in Belagavi and Koppal using WHO growth standards show 32% of children under five are underweight," he said.

He said as per the NITI Aayog (Nourishing India: National Nutritional Strategy), five districts in Karnataka—Ballari, Bagalkot, Koppal, Kalaburagi and Yadgir—are among 100 poor performing districts with very high levels of stunting.

Dharmasthala case: Complainant claims threat to life, seeks police protection

MANGALURU, DHNS: om-plainant-witness in the alleged mass burial case in Dharmasthala, who was released on bail following his arrest on perjury charges, has sought police protection, citing threat to his life.

Chinna S, alias Chinnayya, submitted a petition to the Belthangady police station on December 18, seeking protection for himself and his wife. He stated that Mahesh Shetty Thimmamrody, Girish Mattannavar, Vittal Gowda, Jayanth and Sameer M D could pose a threat to their lives. Based on the petition, a complaint has been registered at Belthangady station and further action will be taken, said police.

Chinnayya had lodged a complaint alleging mass burial in Dharmasthala after which the Dharmasthala police had registered a case initially and later, the case was transferred to Special Investigation Team (SIT). During the SIT investigation, Chinnayya reportedly admitted that the skull he had produced did not belong to the body he claimed to have buried. Following this, SIT officials arrested him on August 23 on the charges of perjury. He was released on bail on December 18.

It suppresses freedom of expression, says Shobha

BENGALURU, DHNS

The state BJP has decided to approach the President of India and has written to the governor against the hate speech pre-

vention bill brought in by the Congress government.

Union Minister Shobha Karandlaje told a news conference on Saturday that in order to silence those who speak against Congress, the government had brought in the bill. "I have written a letter to the governor, requesting not to approve the bill as it suppresses freedom of expression," she said.

The minister said, "The Congress government is imposing an undeclared

emergency. The mentality of Congress is that whatever it does must be accepted without questioning. The bill was passed in the Assembly, without allowing discussion."

"This bill not only violates the boundary between the executive and the judiciary, but also goes against the spirit of the Constitution. If necessary, I will also meet the President," she added.

The minister said, "A fact check agency has been started, giving the responsibility to

Congress workers. It is headed by Minister Priyank Kharge." Shobha alleged that the agency's meeting was held in 2023 under the leadership of Rajneesh Goel.

"There are private people in it. There are some private agencies and institutions that help Congress. For this, Rs 3 to Rs 4 crore is being spent annually," she said.

"Cases have been filed against 35 BJP social media workers, besides MLAs and MLCs, Shobha said.

KBG suspecting own partymen sign of tussle in Cong: Ashoka

BENGALURU, DHNS:

Leader of the Opposition in the Legislative Assembly R Ashoka on Saturday said that the statement by Revenue Minister Krishna Byre Gowda doubting his own party members in the recent land grabbing allegations against him is a sign of ongoing tussle for power within the Congress party.

Writing on X, Ashoka recalled the statement by senior Congress leader and former minister K N Rajanna about

the honey-trap attempts against him and his family members. "Now, another minister suspects that his own party colleagues are conspiring to tarnish his image. Minister Krishna Byre Gowda has said that the land-grab allegations against him are being orchestrated by his own party members," he wrote.

Statement by the minister has held a mirror to the relentless internal squabbles within the Congress party. "Whether it is mere coincidence or a systematic plot that leaders

repeatedly identified with Chief Minister Siddaramaiah's group are being targeted in this way. Who is the 'great leader' behind this conspiracy?" Ashoka sought to know.

Ashoka further stated that his party has no interest in Congress' internal conflicts. However, if the ruling party is engulfed in such infighting, it will have adverse effects on governance and development of the state, he wrote. Ashoka quoted a news item published in *DH* along with his statement on X.

Kerala tourist found dead in lake near Gangavathi

GANGAVATHI (KOPPAL DISTRICT), DHNS: A 34-year-old tourist from Kerala drowned in a lake near Sanapur in Gangavathi taluk on Friday. The deceased has been identified as Cyril Jose. According to police, the tourist was staying at Basapur. On Dec 17, Jose left to explore places nearby and did not return. The following day a missing complaint was lodged. After two days of search, the body of Jose was found floating at Sanapur lake. A case has been registered.

Film celebrating glory of lotus delights kids

SHRADDDHA A K
BENGALURU, DHNS

Feature film 'Padmagandhi', about a young girl enchanted by the lotus, is drawing curious children to the cinemas.

Leela, the protagonist, seeks to understand the significance of the flower, and stumbles on its preeminence in art, literature, religion, spirituality, science and medicine.

K Suchendra Prasad, director, first made the 125-minute

film in Sanskrit, and then dubbed it in Kannada and Hindi. "Focusing on the enduring significance of the lotus, the film subtly reminds viewers of our thriving traditions," he told *DH*.

Now on the big screen in its second week, the film is aimed at young minds. "Padmagandhi" also illuminates the flower's symbolic connection to India's highest civilian awards: the Padma Shri, Padma Bhushan, and Padma Vibhushan. "This emphasises the flower's



A still from the movie 'Padmagandhi'.

deep-rooted place in the cultural consciousness of the nation," said Suchendra Prasad, who has also made a mark as an

actor in several Kannada films. Sanskrit scholar S R Leela's in-depth research, combined with Prasad's own research,

provided the basis for the narrative. Leela has also produced the film, starring Paripoorna Chandrashekhara, Dr. Deepak Paramashivan, Mahapadma, Mrityunjaya Shastri, and others. Cinema in Sanskrit is rare—G V Iyer is known for his films on Sankara, Madhwa and Ramanuja, three great Vedantic acharyas. "Padmagandhi" unfolds a tapestry of ancient history, throwing light on temple sculpture and Vedic teaching, Suchendra Prasad said.

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:: Public Notice ::

(For the Bulk Waste Generators within the jurisdiction of Greater Bengaluru Authority) Management of Bulk Waste through Authorized Waste Processor {M/s Ecosphere Waste Solutions-a subsidiary of M/s Mukka Proteins Limited-AWP-2980316202300562149}

- Whereas, the local authorities to notify SWM Bye-Laws under rule-15(zf) and accordingly, SWM Bye-Laws notified in Gazette vide reference No.: Add. Comm/SWMP/PG-9266/2019-20, dated: 20.04.2020.
- Chapter-VII states about duties of bulk waste generators.
- The bye-law 20(1)(a&b) and 21(2/3/4/5) of SWM Bye-Law 2020 states about identification of bulk waste generators and availing services of Authorized Waste Processors(AWPs) for scientific management of solid waste and domestic hazardous & sanitary waste.
- The bye-law 21(7) of SWM Bye-Law 2020 states about the intimation to be given to authority (BSWML) about availing the services of Authorized Waste Processors authorized by the concerned authority (BSWML).
- Whereas, rule-4(3) of SWM Rules-2016 states about payment of user fees by waste generators as notified and also, rule-15(f) states about collection of user fees from waste generators.
- Hon'ble National Green Tribunal, Principal Bench, New Delhi has also directed and stressed upon implementation of "Polluter Pays Principle" in its several judgment orders issued in O.A.No.:606/2018.
- The Government of Karnataka notified user fee vide reference No.: UDD 500 MNY 2024(E), dated: 04.03.2025 in which maximum service charge for bulk waste management is capped at Rs.12/- per kg.
- The Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Limited being an agency of Greater Bengaluru Authority in exercise of the powers conferred under section 272(1) of GBG Act 2024, SWM Bye-Laws 2020 and SWM Rules 2016; by following due diligence and strictly adhering to the transparent procedure, has empaneled **M/s Mukka Proteins Limited** as Authorized Waste Processor (certificate no. 2980316202300562149) and mapped to the jurisdiction of Bengaluru North City Corporation and Bengaluru East City Corporation along with cross boundary areas authorizing them to engage with the bulk waste generators to operate for collection, transportation, processing and disposal strictly in accordance with the SWM Rules-2016 and BBMP SWM Bye-Laws 2020.
- It is notified for strict acknowledgment/adoption by all the bulk waste generators (as per bye law-20(1)) viz. residential/commercial/institutional/others in the jurisdiction of Bengaluru North City Corporation and Bengaluru East City Corporation along with cross boundary areas to tie up with the **M/s Ecosphere Waste Solutions-a subsidiary of M/s Mukka Proteins Limited- an Authorized Waste Processor (AWP certificate no. 2980316202300562149)** with immediate effect for scientific management of bulk waste to be compliant and adhered to statutory rules/laws.
- It is also, notified that none other than M/s Ecosphere Waste Solutions-a subsidiary of M/s Mukka Proteins Limited(AWP certificate no. 2980316202300562149) is/are authorized/empaneled as Authorized Waste Processor (AWP) of Greater Bengaluru Authority in the jurisdiction of Bengaluru North City Corporation and Bengaluru East City Corporation along with cross boundary areas.
- It is notified for information of all bulk waste generators in the jurisdiction of Bengaluru North City Corporation and Bengaluru East City Corporation along with cross boundary areas that any non-compliance or if any, disposal through unauthorized operators will attract penalty in accordance with the SWM Bye Laws, Environmental Compensation in accordance with the CPCB Guidelines and action in accordance with the provisions of GBGA 2024.
- The Bulk Waste Generators shall submit annual return to BSWML as required in compliance to bye-law 14(7) of SWM Bye-Law 2020.
- If there is no authorized waste processor mapped/notified by BSWML/not available as per BSWML for management of bulk waste in other areas/corporations other than the jurisdiction of Bangalore North Municipal Corporation and Bangalore East Municipal Corporation including cross-boundary areas, of the Greater Bangalore Authority; or if bulk waste generator wishes, shall tie up with M/s Ecosphere Waste Solutions - {A subsidiary of M/s Mukka Proteins Limited (C.N.: 2980316202300562149)} to manage the bulk waste through a mutually agreed legal procedure. In no case, unauthorized disposal through unauthorized vendor is allowed. Green/Eco-friendly vehicles shall be deployed as far as possible.
- The decision of Bangalore Solid Waste Management Limited (agency of GBA) is final in case of notification of authorized waste processor for management of bulk waste as per SWM bye Laws 2020.

Sd/-
Chief Executive Officer
Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Limited

DIPRC/CP4493/SSC/2025-26